

Session 5: Scripture, Communication, Language, and Culture

Key Takeaways

- Although it can be a difficult task, it is valuable to remain open to perspectives different from our own.
- The Bible is an ancient text produced within a specific culture, but this does not diminish its capacity to speak to us.
- Awareness of the ancient cultural context of the Bible begins with maintaining intellectual humility, identifying our assumptions, opening ourselves to other perspectives, being aware of cultural differences, and having some understanding of how biblical literature works.

Scripture, Communication, Language, and Culture

Revolutionary Fact #1: The Bible is an ancient text, but some people don't treat it like one when it comes to interpreting Genesis chapter 1.

Revolutionary Fact #2: Any act of communication, including God's communication in Scripture, can only convey meaning within a particular language and historical/cultural context.

"Effective communication requires a body of agreed-upon words, terms, and ideas, a common ground of understanding. For the speaker, this often requires accommodation to the audience by using words and ideas they will understand. For the audience, if they are not native to the language and cultural matrix of the speaker, this means reaching common ground may require seeking out additional information or explanation. In other words, the audience has to adapt to a new and unfamiliar culture."

Walton, John H. (2006). [*Ancient Near Eastern Thought And The Old Testament*](#). Baker Academic. 19-20.

Reading the Bible, including Genesis 1, is a cross-cultural experience. We have to step into a different cultural worldview in order to understand what its authors are trying to communicate. It is only when we step outside the controversial debates of our contemporary culture and try to read Genesis 1 in its ancient context that we can make headway in true understanding of this chapter's meaning.

Reflection Question

If you were traveling to a foreign country you'd never visited before, you would expect different customs and prepare accordingly. Apply this idea to reading the Bible. How can you engage it on its own terms as an ancient and foreign text?